

SPOILER-FREE PREVIEW

A family story under pressure.

Read an opening scene and one genuine exhibit from the expanded narrative edition. This preview contains no solution or hidden identity disclosure.

Inside the complete game: a sustained character story, an archive of inspectable records, working pages, progressive hints, an evidence-cited solution, and an expanded aftermath.

Play alone or investigate together. Every required clue is in the supplied papers. Print in grayscale or use the PDF bookmarks and catalog. No host or outside research is needed.

Player file: 36 pages. Preview pages are selected excerpts; their archive and story labels match the full edition.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The question before the wedding

Before the opening brief / Mabel's family story

Edith had always been able to tell the story of the basket. The church, the little girl, the home waiting for her. When Mabel was small, the telling ended with Edith drawing her close. It was a good ending for a child who wanted to be certain she belonged.

As a grown woman preparing to enter her name in another register, Mabel discovered that the same ending could close a door.

"What am I to put?" she asked.

Edith looked at the paper. "Sutton. You've always been Sutton."

"I know my name. I mean before."

Thomas kept his eyes on the table. He could repair a thing with a split in it. He could not make this question fit neatly beside the life they had given her.

Edith reached to straighten Mabel's sleeve. Mabel let her. She loved that hand. She also wanted it to stop answering questions nobody had asked.

"We don't have those names," Edith said.

"Then I want to look."

For a moment Edith's face made Mabel feel as though she had announced she was leaving them. The unfairness of that feeling brought heat to her eyes. She had not wanted an argument. She had wanted permission not to know something and still need to know it.

"Was there something you lacked here?" Edith asked.

Thomas moved then, drawing a chair out so Mabel could sit. "She asked about the papers."

Edith looked at him, hurt. He did not withdraw the chair.

Mabel sat. "I can be grateful and ask. Can't I?"

The answer took long enough to matter.

Edith put her hand flat on the table. "Yes."

They had no account of the person who carried the basket. The old newspaper did not provide one. Thomas and Edith could tell Mabel how she had come into their care, but their love did not turn that knowledge into a birth record.

Mabel drew the clipping toward her. For the first time she read the estimate of the infant's age as something a doctor had tried to judge, not as the beginning of a story she had to accept whole.

She wanted a name. She was afraid of the reason it had been taken away. Across the table, Edith was afraid that finding it would make Sutton seem smaller. Neither fear could choose the answer. Somewhere in the county's ordinary papers, other children had been entered under other parents' names.

Sutton household

Warren County, Ohio / census date: 15 April 1910

THIRTEENTH CENSUS OF THE UNITED STATES

POPULATION SCHEDULE / selected columns / household extract

Name	Relation to head	Age	Birthplace	Occupation
<i>Sutton, Thomas</i>	<i>Head</i>	<i>42</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	<i>carpenter</i>
<i>Sutton, Edith</i>	<i>Wife</i>	<i>38</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Sutton, Mabel R.</i>	<i>Daughter</i>	<i>10</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-
<i>Mercer, Lydia</i>	<i>Mother-in-law</i>	<i>62</i>	<i>Ohio</i>	-

CIVIL STATE

Thomas: married. Edith: married. Lydia: widowed.

MOTHER OF HOW MANY CHILDREN

Edith Sutton - Number born: 0. Number now living: 0.

Residents named in this household extract are shown above. A dash means a field was not copied; it does not mean zero.